REMARKS BY THE STATISTICIAN-GENERAL OF THE FEDERATION AND CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER, NATIONAL BUREAU OF STATISTICS, PRINCE ADEYEMI ADENIRAN AT THE 50TH ANNUAL CONFERENCE OF THE CHARTERED INSTITUTE OF STATISTICIANS OF NIGERIA (CISON)

Theme: From Legacy to Leadership: 50 Years of Promoting Statistical Development in Nigeria

14th October 2026 | Chida Hotel, Utako, Abuja

Protocols,

1. Distinguished President and Council Members of the Chartered Institute of Statisticians of Nigeria (CISON), esteemed colleagues, ladies and gentlemen, it is a great honour to address the 50th Annual Conference of the Institute. I thank the President, the Council and the members for inviting me, and I congratulate you all on this landmark anniversary.

2. This jubilee is more than a count of years. It marks fifty years of a profession that has quietly shaped how Nigeria counts, plans and decides, and it is a testament to the dedication of those who built it.

3. The theme of this conference, From Legacy to Leadership, is fitting for an event such as this. It asks two fundamental questions: What have we inherited? And what must we now lead? I will address both. I will then say plainly what the National Bureau of Statistics asks of the Institute, and what the Bureau offers in return.

4. First, the legacy. In 1976, statisticians, economists, planners and demographers came together to form the Nigerian Statistical Association. They believed that statistics deserved a professional home. Over the decades, the Association built a community of practice through annual

conferences, workshops, competitions for young students, and a steady call for legal recognition of the profession.

5. That call was answered when the National Assembly established the Chartered Institute. The step from association to a chartered institute mattered. It signalled that statistics is not only a subject to be studied but a profession held to standards the public can rely on. It also gave Nigeria a body that can speak for the profession, set expectations for practitioners, and help shape how statistics is taught.

6. Over the same five decades, the Nigerian statistical system has changed beyond recognition. We began with largely manual record-keeping. Today, official statistics sit at the heart of national planning and policy decision-making. The foresight of the founding members, and the passion for integrity, professionalism and capacity building shown by the trailblazers of the early years, laid that foundation. Every milestone we celebrate reflects decades of hard work and sacrifice by those who came before us.

7. Many of the people who produce Nigeria's official statistics today were taught, mentored or inspired by members of this Institute. The Bureau, the State statistical offices, the universities, the Central Bank, the ministries and the private sector all draw on that pool of talent. Every consumer price index, every national account and every household survey rests on the patient work of such professionals, much of it unseen. On behalf of the Bureau, I thank you immensely.

8. Second, why this matters now. Nigeria is in a period of reform. Citizens, investors and development partners are asking hard questions about prices, jobs, growth and living standards, and they are putting those questions to the data. Households want to know whether the figures match what they see

in the market. Businesses want to know whether they can plan on them. Policymakers want to know whether a measure is working before it is too late to adjust.

9. In recent years, the role of statistics has been recognised as never before. Government, the private sector, development partners and civil society now accept that accurate, timely and relevant data drive development. That recognition has helped Nigeria engage global partners, track commitments such as the Sustainable Development Goals, and respond to challenges from pandemics to climate change.

10. But recognition also raises the stakes. It also reminds us that trust in statistics is earned through sound methods, open explanation and professional integrity. A figure is only as credible as the people who stand behind it.

11. When a statistician explains a method, admits a limitation, or openly corrects a revision, public confidence grows. Our shared task is to keep Nigerians confident that official statistics are produced honestly, professionally, and for the public good.

12. There is a second pressure. The demand for data, especially at the state and local level, is rising faster than the supply of people trained to produce it well. Governments want figures for their States. Planners want data on women, youth, persons with disabilities and other groups who are too often left uncounted. That gap between demand and capacity is the real test of our profession.

13. What the Bureau has done. Let me say briefly where the Bureau stands, because our work and yours are closely linked. We have modernised data

collection through digital technologies, geospatial tools and stronger administrative data systems, with measurable gains in the quality and timeliness of our statistics.

14. With partners, we have developed the third National Strategy for the Development of Statistics, NSDS III. Its three focus areas are technology and modernisation, adequate financing, and applying statistics so the nation can realise its data dividend. We have advanced the Integrated System of Administrative Statistics, so records held by ministries, departments, and agencies can become reliable official statistics. We have computed Gross Domestic Product for the States nationwide for the first time. We have begun reviewing the Statistics Act, so our legal framework matches the demands of a modern statistical system.

15. I must also be honest about the challenges. Financing for data production remains inadequate. Some public institutions do not document or share their data effectively. Harmonisation across the National Statistical System remains incomplete, and statistical literacy among the public and decision-makers remains low. None of these can be solved by the Bureau alone. A strong professional institute can help in each area.

16. Third, leadership. If the first fifty years were about building a profession, the next fifty must be about leading with it. I see four priorities.

17. Uphold standards and ethics. In a world awash with misinformation, a chartered profession is only as strong as its code of conduct. The public must know that a statistician will report what the data show, state the limits of the evidence, and resist pressure to say otherwise. The independence of the Bureau under the Statistics Act, and the professional discipline of this Institute, reinforce each other. Together, they protect the one asset official

statistics cannot do without: credibility. The trust society places in us is our greatest asset, and we must guard it jealously.

18. Build the next generation of skills. Our work is changing. Administrative data, geospatial tools, digital collection, big data and artificial intelligence are now part of daily practice. Young statisticians must learn these alongside sound sampling, estimation and national accounts. That requires curricula that keep pace, practical placements, and mentors from this very room. It also requires deliberate effort to bring more women and young people into the profession and give them real responsibility early. I urge every member of the Institute to take up the mantle of mentorship and to champion statistical education at all levels. The Bureau's School of Statistics stands ready to work with the Institute and the universities.

19. Use new tools responsibly. New technology offers speed and detail that we could not have imagined fifty years ago. It also brings risks: weak data protection, opaque procedures, and figures that look precise but rest on poor foundations. The profession must lead on these questions. A statistician should be able to say what a model assumes, how it was tested, and where it should not be trusted. Protecting the privacy of respondents is not optional. It is the basis on which Nigerians agree to answer our questions. We must also invest in data literacy beyond our own ranks, so that data can inform public debate and empower citizens.

20. Strengthen the National Statistical System, at home and abroad. Official statistics are produced by many hands: the Bureau, ministries, departments and agencies, the States, the Central Bank, universities and partners. Under NSDS-III, we are working to coordinate these producers,

avoid duplication, share data more openly, modernise our tools and secure adequate financing.

21. We must also engage more closely with the private sector, academia and civil society, because in an era of unprecedented data generation, the collective expertise of all stakeholders is our strongest resource. Professional statisticians in each of these institutions are the System's connective tissue. Beyond our borders, Nigeria is looked to as a leader in Africa. We should actively participate in continental and international forums, share our best practices, and learn from others.

22. Let me now be clear about what we ask of the Institute. We ask for four things.

23. One, work with us to set professional standards and accreditation pathways for statisticians in the National Statistical System, so that the people who produce public data are recognised for their competence.

24. Two, help align university curricula with the skills that official statistics now demand, including practical training in survey methods, national accounts, data science and data ethics.

25. Three, support our advocacy for data sharing by public institutions, for adequate and timely financing of data production, and for the review of the Statistics Act.

26. Four, be public voices for statistical literacy. When a figure is misunderstood, explain it. When a method is questioned, engage with evidence and courtesy. Your members teach in classrooms, advise in boardrooms and speak in the media. You reach audiences that the Bureau alone cannot.

27. In return, the Bureau commits to open consultation on methods, published release calendars, clear notes on revisions and limitations, and a standing partnership with the Institute on training and standards. We will also open our technical forums to your members, so the profession is part of the conversation before decisions are made, not after.

28. Fifty years ago, a small group of professionals gave statistics a home. Today, we are its custodians. The founders built the house. Our duty is to keep it sound, open its doors to the young, and ensure that what is produced inside it serves every Nigerian. Legacy is what they built. Leadership is what we do with it: with honesty, skill, and courage.

29. I congratulate CISON once again on this golden milestone, and I wish you all a successful, productive and inspiring conference.

Thank you, and God bless the Federal Republic of Nigeria.